Setting up a Zoho Creator account and exploring the platform architecture and interface.

Name: Vaideeshwari K
Roll no : 241401121

1. Introduction

Zoho Creator is a cloud-based, low-code application development platform that enables users to build web and mobile applications with minimal programming effort. It offers a drag-and-drop interface along with built-in tools for automation, database management, reporting, and workflow integration. The objective of this exploration was to get familiar with the Zoho Creator interface, walk through its key modules, and understand how each of these features supports the process of building and managing an application.

2. Account Creation

The exploration began by signing up for a Zoho Creator account using the college Google account. During registration, basic details such as name, email address, and mobile number were entered, and the terms and conditions were accepted to complete the sign-up. Once the account was created, it was automatically activated with a free trial, giving access to most of the platform's core features and modules for evaluation purposes.

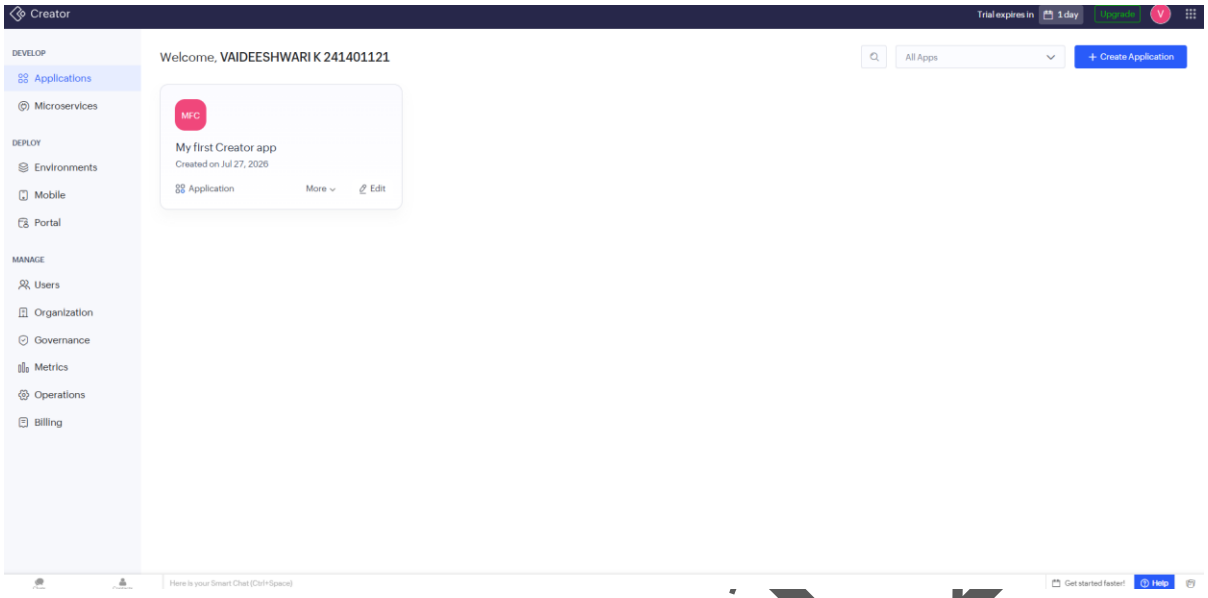
3. Dashboard Overview

After logging in, the Zoho Creator dashboard appeared as the central hub for managing applications and account settings. The top bar displayed the remaining trial period along with quick access to upgrade options and the user profile icon. A default sample application, “My first Creator app”, was already present on the dashboard, which made it easier to understand how applications are listed and organised. The left-hand navigation panel grouped the platform's features under three clear categories — Develop, Deploy, and Manage — which made the overall layout intuitive to explore even without prior experience.

4. Applications Module

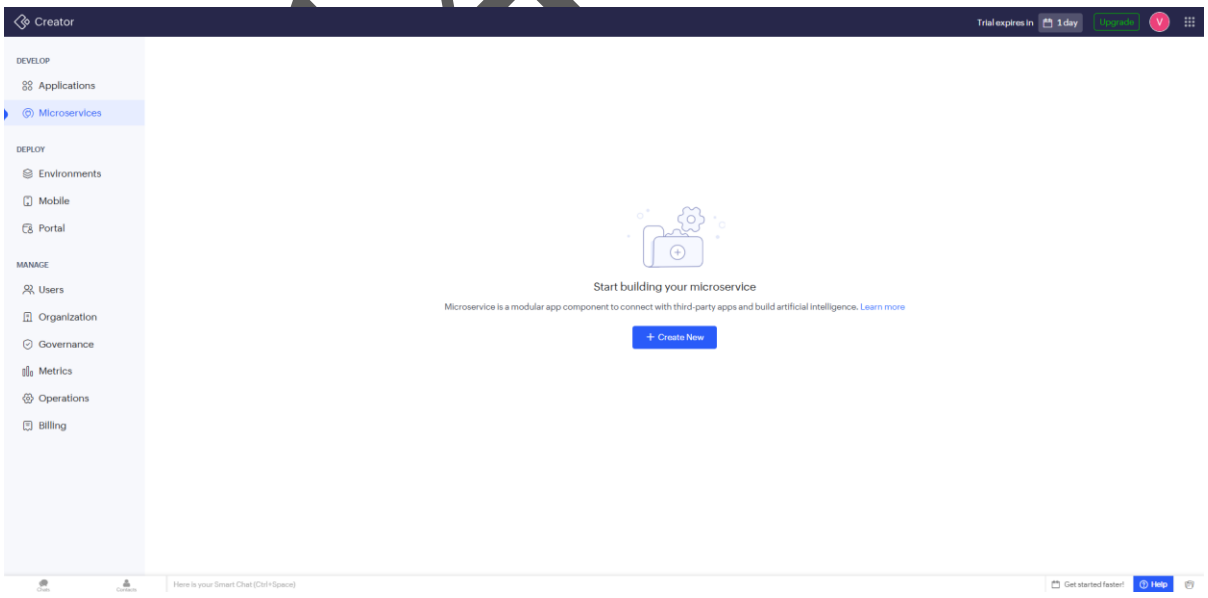
The Applications module, listed under the Develop section, is the main workspace for creating and managing applications within Zoho Creator. It lists all existing applications and provides options to create a new application, edit an existing one, or view its settings. While exploring this section, the default sample application was visible along with the “Application” and “Edit” options, which clarified how applications are organised, opened, and modified within the platform.

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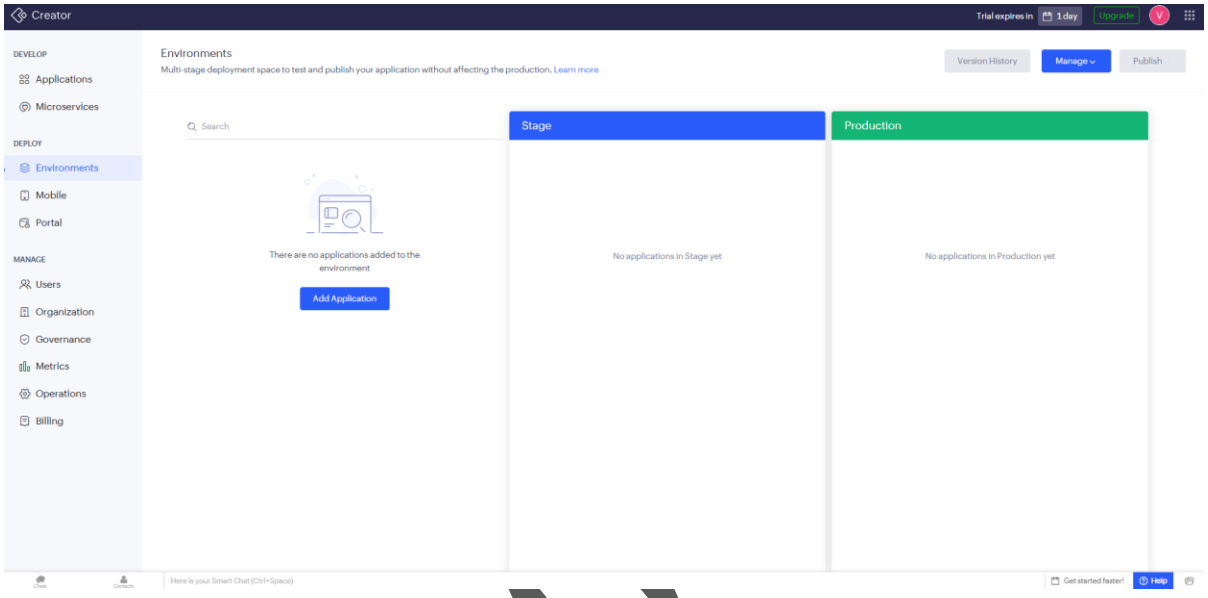
5. Microservices Module

The Microservices section allows developers to build small, modular components that can connect with third-party applications or power artificial-intelligence features through APIs. No microservice was created during this exploration, but the module clearly displayed a “Start building your microservice” prompt along with a “Create New” option. This module would be particularly useful in scenarios where an application needs to integrate with an external system or share data across services.



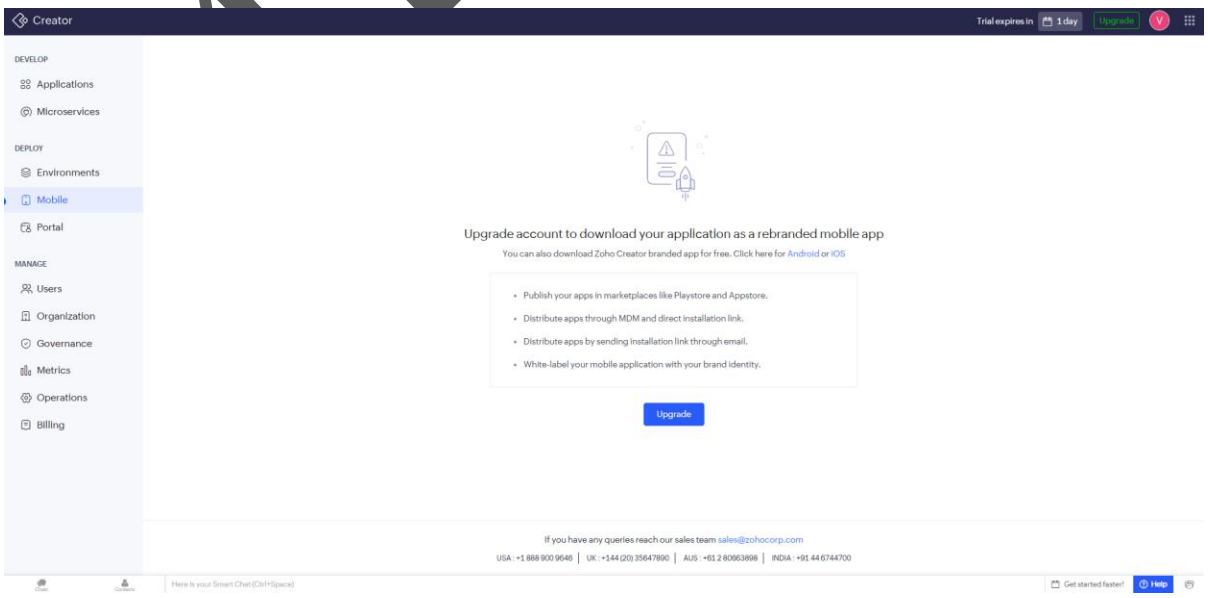
6. Environments Module

The Environments module, found under the Deploy section, helps manage an application's lifecycle across separate Stage and Production spaces, allowing changes to be tested before they are released to end users. During the exploration, no application had been added to either environment, but the split-panel layout made it clear how Zoho Creator keeps the testing and live versions of an application isolated from one another to avoid errors reaching production.



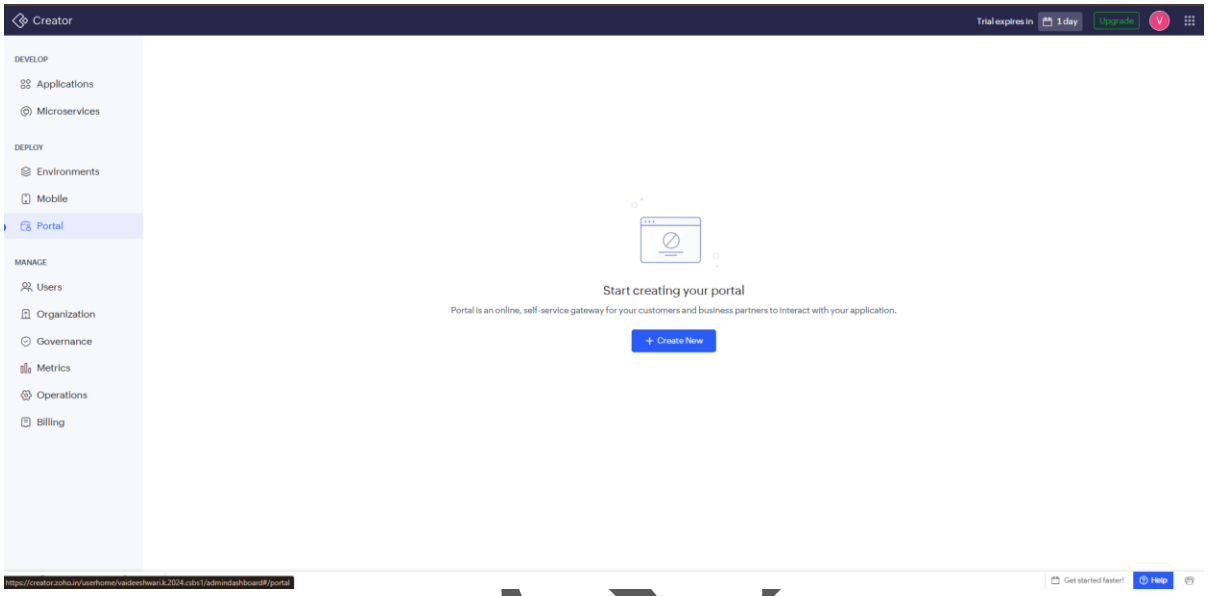
7. Mobile Module

The Mobile module shows how a Zoho Creator application can be extended into a mobile app. Exploring this section revealed that publishing apps to the Play Store and App Store, distributing them through MDM or an installation link, and white-labelling the app with custom branding are all features available once the account is upgraded from the trial plan. This module highlights how the same application built for the web can also be deployed as a branded mobile app.



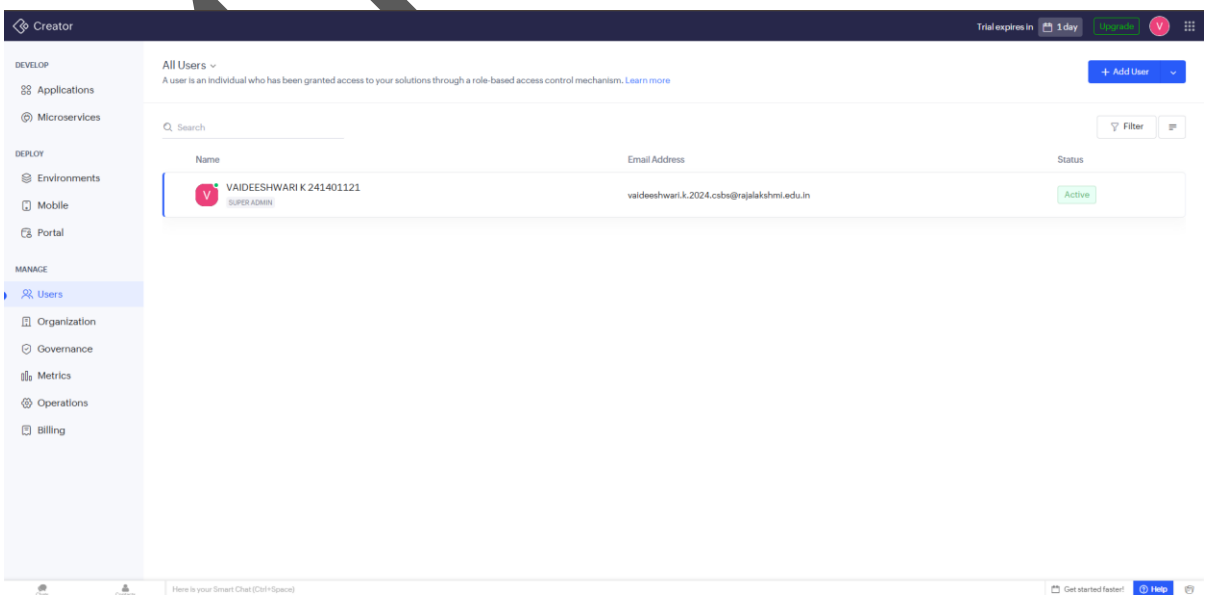
8. Portal Module

The Portal module is used to create a dedicated, self-service web portal for customers or business partners to interact with an application. While no portal was created during this exploration, the “Start creating your portal” screen with the “Create New” option made it evident how this feature can be used to grant external users limited, secure access to specific parts of an application without exposing the entire system.



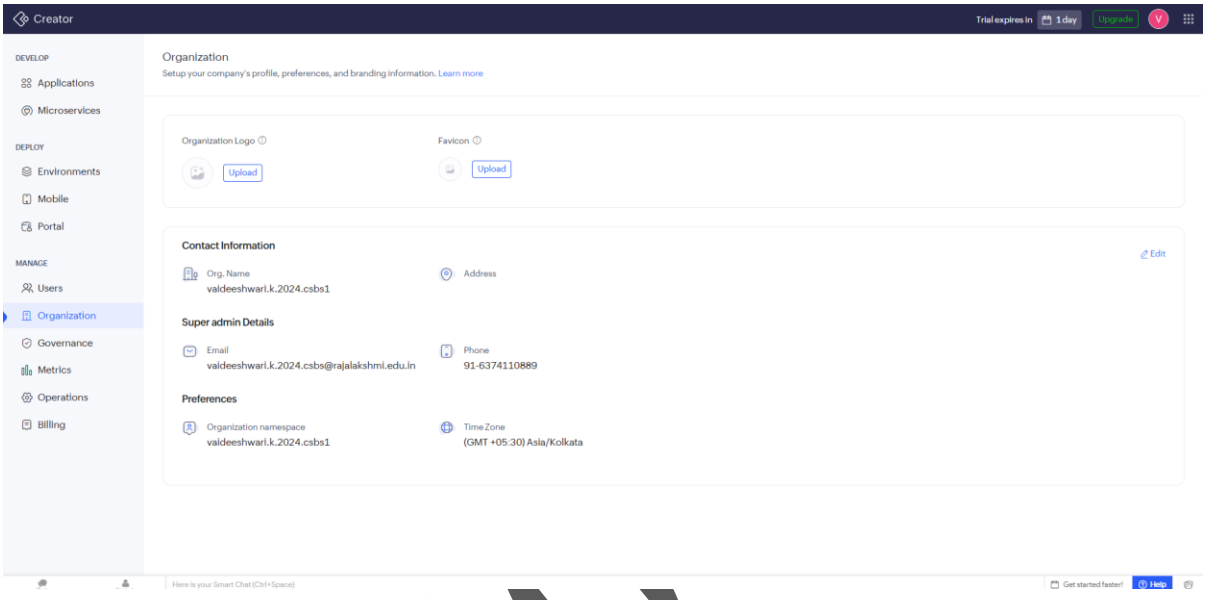
9. Users Module

The Users module, under the Manage section, is used to control who has access to an application and what permissions they hold. During the exploration, the registered account appeared as the sole user with the “Super Admin” role and an “Active” status. There was also an option to add further users, which shows how this module supports role-based access when multiple people collaborate on the same application.



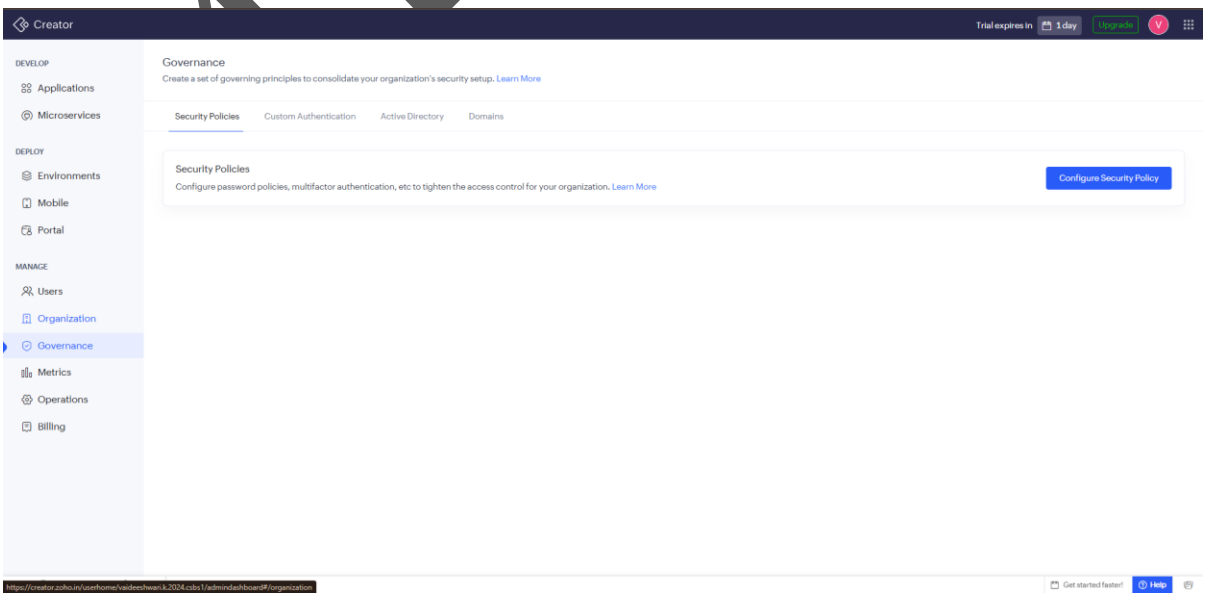
10. Organization Module

The Organization module allows the account holder to manage company-level details such as the organisation logo, favicon, contact information, super admin details, and preferences like the organisation namespace and time zone. Exploring this section showed the organisation name, registered email, phone number, and the time zone set to (GMT +05:30) Asia/Kolkata, which together give the account and its applications a consistent, organisation-specific identity.



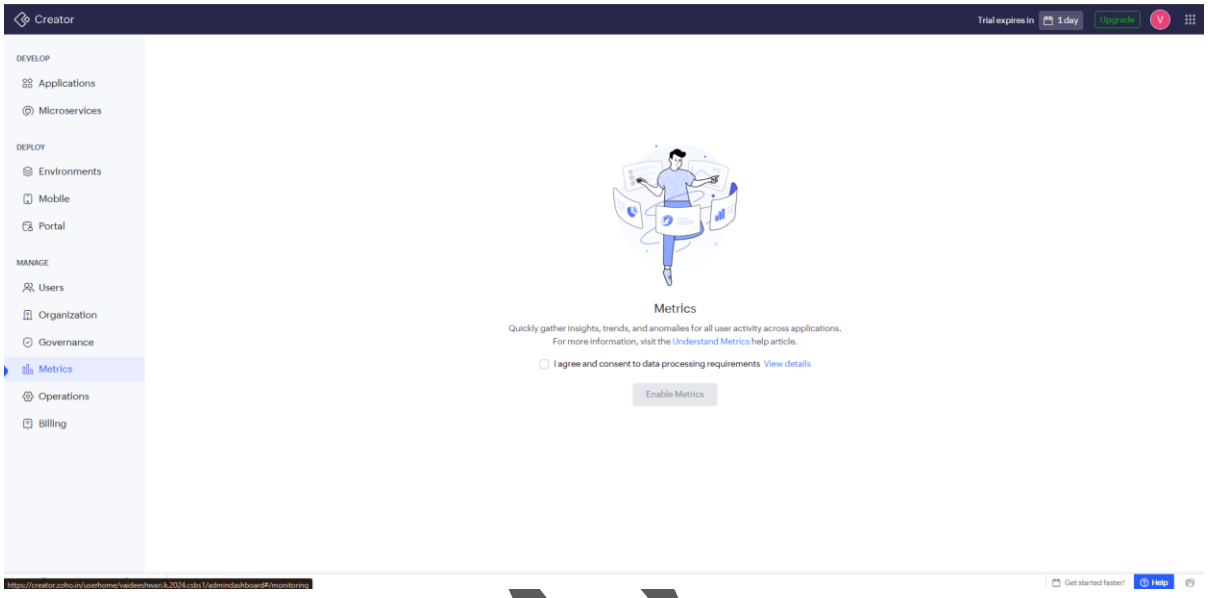
11. Governance Module

The Governance module is focused on securing the organisation's applications and controlling how users authenticate. It offers tabs for Security Policies, Custom Authentication, Active Directory, and Domains. No security configuration was changed during the exploration, but the “Configure Security Policy” option under Security Policies showed how password rules and multi-factor authentication can be enforced to strengthen account security.



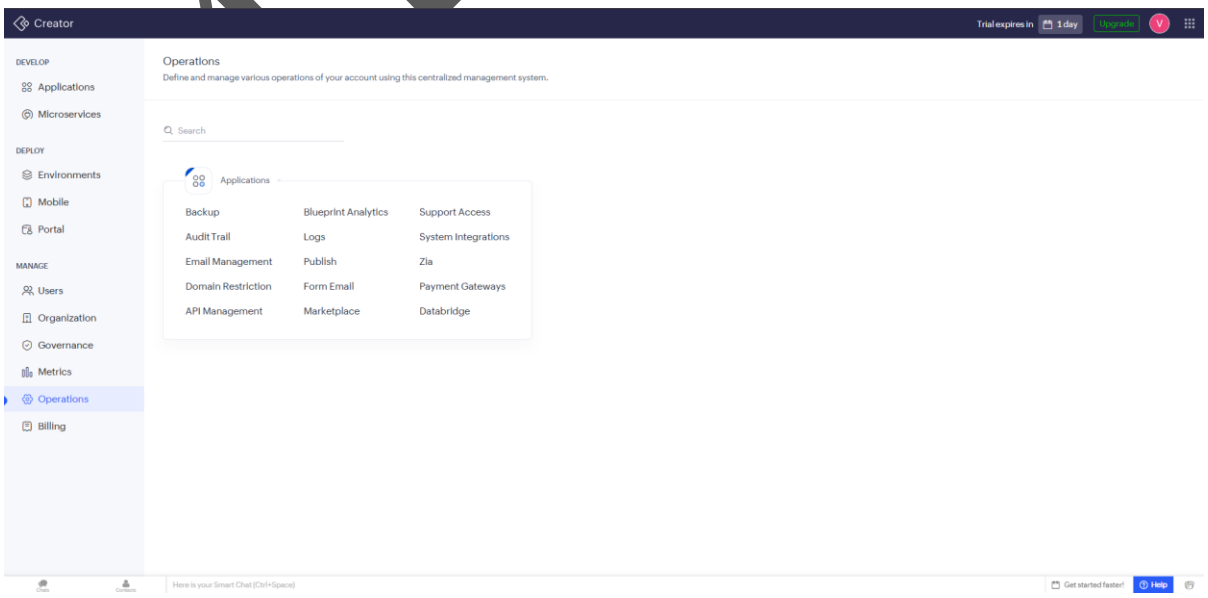
12. Metrics Module

The Metrics module is designed to provide insights, trends, and anomalies related to user activity across applications. Before this feature can be enabled, the user is required to explicitly agree to the data processing requirements, as shown by the consent checkbox next to the “Enable Metrics” button. This confirms that Zoho Creator places importance on user consent and privacy before collecting any usage-related data.



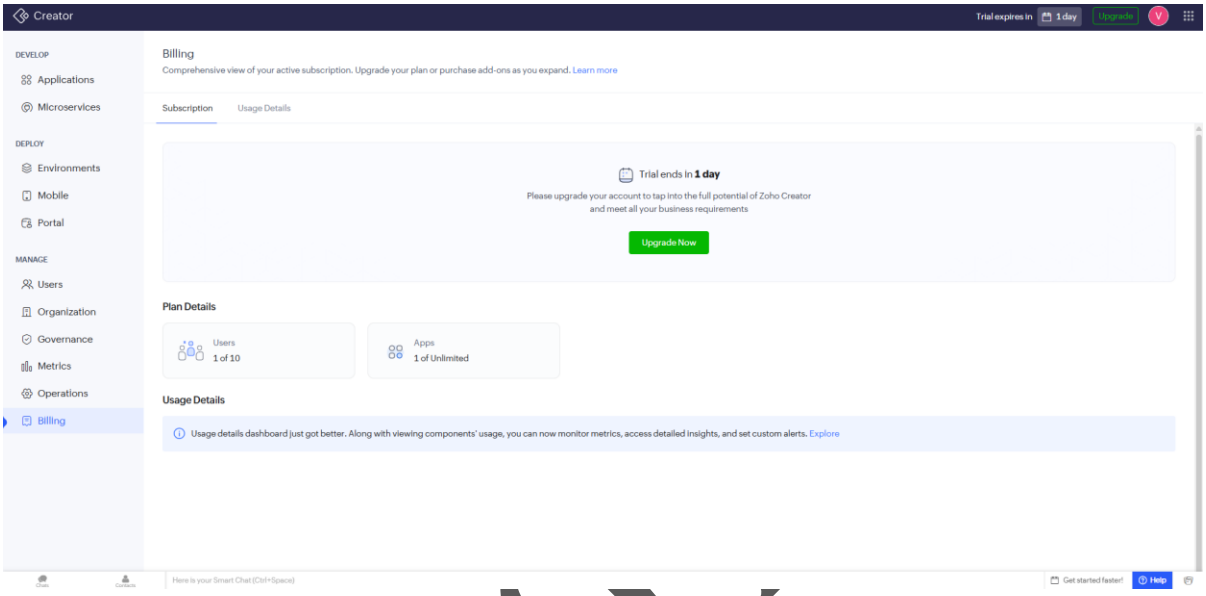
13. Operations Module

The Operations module brings together the tools needed to manage an application after it has been built. It consolidates features such as Backup, Audit Trail, Email Management, Domain Restriction, API Management, Blueprint Analytics, Logs, Publish, Form Email, Marketplace, Support Access, System Integrations, Zia, Payment Gateways, and Databridge. Together, these tools make ongoing application maintenance, monitoring, and integration far more organised and centralised.



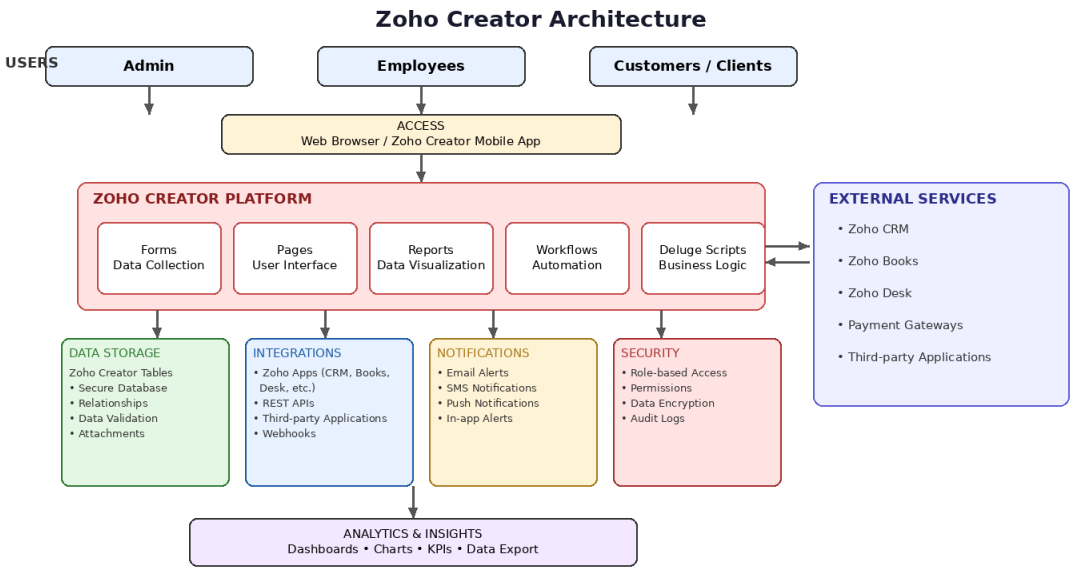
14. Billing Module

The Billing module gives a complete view of the account's active subscription, trial status, and usage details. At the time of this exploration, the trial was set to end in 1 day, with the plan allowing up to 10 users and unlimited applications. The Subscription and Usage Details tabs made it easy to review the current plan limits and see the available options for upgrading once the trial period ends.



Zoho Creator Architecture

The diagram below summarises the overall architecture of Zoho Creator based on the modules explored above. Users — admins, employees, and customers — access the platform through a web browser or the Zoho Creator mobile app. The platform itself is built around Forms, Pages, Reports, Workflows, and Deluge scripts, which together handle data collection, interface design, visualization, automation, and business logic. These components connect to secure data storage, integrations with Zoho and third-party applications, notification channels, and security controls, and can also communicate with external services such as Zoho CRM, Zoho Books, Zoho Desk, and payment gateways. The processed data ultimately feeds into dashboards, charts, and KPIs for analytics and insights.



Conclusion

Overall, this exploration of Zoho Creator provided a clear, hands-on understanding of how a low-code platform supports the end-to-end lifecycle of building and managing applications. Walking through modules such as Applications, Microservices, Environments, Mobile, Portal, Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, and Billing showed how development, deployment, security, and administration are all brought together within a single, well-organised interface. This exercise offered a strong starting point for building more advanced applications on the platform in the future.

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